# PROPOSED
# *NEW* POLICY

**Information Item**

**Rationale:** In December 2021, the U.S. Surgeon General issued a public health advisory regarding the mental health challenges facing youth. The advisory calls for a response from all communities including schools, teachers, and parents. The national increase in youth depression and anxiety, as well as the increase in behaviors such as impulsivity and irritability are evidence of increasing youth mental health issues. Consequently, mental health professionals believe children are experiencing trauma at an unprecedented high level, including:

- Nearly two-thirds of youth experiencing a traumatic event by the time they reach adulthood;
- Many youths exposed to trauma experiencing an array of short and long-term mental health problems, including posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD);
- School support providing 70-80% of all mental health services; and
- A need to enhance the consistent availability and use of evidence-based interventions in schools for youth exposed to trauma.

This proposed policy creates greater awareness and supports appropriate responses by school staff to the effects of trauma on student learning and behavior. The policy and procedure encourage embedding culturally responsive and trauma-informed concepts into current policies and procedure, into professional development programs, utilization of a trauma-informed lens, and bi-annual school and district level evaluations of trauma informed practices. Additionally, the district will collect participation data from trainings. This participation data will be used to evaluate the effectiveness of training on reducing discipline, disruptive behavior, and attendance. As needed, staff will be provided additional training or training will be revised to ensure better outcomes.

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## Trauma Informed Schools

The Board of Directors of Vancouver Public Schools recognizes the impact that trauma may have on the educational environment of the schools, individual student achievement, and the school community. The board desires to address the effects of trauma to meet the academic, behavioral and professional needs of students. The purpose of this policy is to state the board's commitment to providing trauma informed schools and culturally responsive programs where all students feel included, welcomed, valued, and supported; and where addressing trauma's impact on learning school-wide is integral to the district's educational mission.

The district will strive to create physically and emotionally safe, and culturally responsive environments for all students and families through effective professional development, practices, and instruction in the following areas: 1) understanding the widespread impact of trauma and the role of schools in promoting resiliency; 2) recognizing and responding to the signs and symptoms of trauma in students and families; and 3) integrating knowledge about trauma and social emotional learning for children.

Additionally, to achieve a trauma informed approach the district will implement district programs, partnerships with outside agencies, and policies and procedures through a trauma-informed lens. Specifically, policies that focus on identifying, valuing, and integrating the cultures, languages, heritage

and experiences of all students to ensure a supportive school climate and community. This shall include, but not be limited to, implementation of the following existing policies and procedures that support trauma informed practices:

1. 0010- Equity
2. 3131- Student attendance
3. 3241- Student Discipline
4. 2020- Curriculum and Instruction
5. 6700- Nutrition Health and Physical Education
6. 2161- Special Education
7. 5830- District Resource Officers
8. 4900- Civility
9. 6020- Budget
10. 5515- Workforce Secondary Traumatic Stress; and
11. 6800- Maintenance of Facilities.

The superintendent will create a procedure to support trauma informed practices at the district and school level. No later than March 1st each school year, the superintendent will provide the board a progress report on implementation of this policy and procedure.

Legal References:

Adopted:

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